

By specifying which programs are authorised to run on your system you ensure that only those programs are allowed to launch. Any attempt by any other program to start with or without the user's knowledge will be unsuccessful.

2.12. Securing the Linux Desktop

Linux has acquired a reputation for being “virus-free” and more secure than Windows. However, vulnerabilities do exist, and Linux, more often than not, is not optimally configured for the home user. Thus, home users will need to close off some of the potential vulnerabilities manually.

Standard Linux installations will have many services that are started with the operating system. These, in most cases, are useless for the home user. For example, the FTP service runs an ftp server that is used to transfer files to and from the PC. This is not required on home PCs as home users will be primarily downloading files. The FTP service is useful if you are storing files that are downloaded by a large number of users. Similarly, the SMTP service is an e-mail service that is not required on most home PCs. The programs that run these services are known as daemons. These daemons run in the background waiting for some event to occur to respond to. To secure the Desktop, disable all unnecessary services from starting when the system boots up.

Inetd

Inetd is a super daemon that controls a number of network daemons. You will need to modify the configuration file `inetd.conf` to disable all unnecessary services. Open the `inetd.conf` file, normally found in the `/etc` folder, in a text editor like `pico`. To do that, open a terminal window and type “`pico /etc/inetd.conf`”. Scroll through the entries looking for listings like:

```
ftp stream tcp nowait /usr/etc/in.ftp in.ftp
```